

Employee based brand equity: a systematic review of literature, framework development, and implications for future research

Employee-based brand equity

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Abstract

Purpose – Through a systematic literature review, this paper aims to endeavor to present a thorough historical perspective on the evolution of employee-based brand equity (EBBE), offering a comprehensive understanding of its development. The study explores the general model, causes and effects of EBBE, as well as the role of culture, leadership and brand management in building EBBE. The paper proposes an integrative framework to understand the interrelationships between the various dimensions of EBBE and offers practical guidelines for future research and the business world.

Design/methodology/approach – The paper uses a systematic literature review approach to analyze and synthesize 30 studies on EBBE retrieved from SCOPUS and Web of Science. The analysis involves a thematic and content-based examination of the literature, which is organized into three thematic groups.

Findings – The review highlights the importance of EBBE as a driver of organizational performance and success. The paper identifies the evolution of the major themes, trends and debates in the literature and suggests areas for future research. It underscores the need for more qualitative, multi-level and longitudinal research on EBBE, as well as the exploration of the links between EBBE and other forms of brand equity.

Originality/value – This paper is one of the first systematic literature reviews of EBBE, offering a comprehensive and integrated view of the existing literature since the beginning of this concept. The paper's originality lies in its proposed integrative framework that captures the interrelationships between the various dimensions of EBBE and provides practical guidelines for future research and the business world.

Keywords Employee based brand equity, Internal brand management, Brand equity, Systematic literature review

Paper type Literature review

1. Introduction

Employee-based brand equity (EBBE) has become a popular topic of research in recent years, with an increasing number of studies exploring its significance and impact on businesses. Despite the growing interest in the topic of EBBE, there remains a significant gap in the understanding of this concept. While numerous authors have made valuable contributions by exploring various aspects of EBBE, such as new variables, dimensions and



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connections, a historical view and an integrated understanding that connects all of these findings have yet to be achieved (Boukis and Christodoulides, 2020; Mavuso *et al.*, 2020; Sarangal, 2018; Tavassoli *et al.*, 2014). Although individual studies have shed light on specific components of EBBE, it was missing a single study that synthesizes and consolidates all of this knowledge into a unified framework and that reveals the evolution of this concept. This poses a challenge for both researchers and practitioners who seek a cohesive understanding of the mechanisms, antecedents and outcomes of EBBE.

This article aims to address this gap by providing a systematic literature review of EBBE, identifying its evolution, key themes and debates, and proposing an integrative framework for understanding the interplay between various dimensions of EBBE. Additionally, this article provides practical guidelines for businesses looking to enhance their EBBE.

The concept of “brand” has garnered considerable attention from scholars over the years, resulting in a multitude of definitions and making it a central subject of investigation (Aaker, 1996; Keller, 1993, 1998; Kotler, 1991). A brand can be defined as a symbol or a name, as a product or as “a means of symbolic framing for utilitarian and non-utilitarian values” (Ballantyne and Aitken, 2007, p. 364). In other words, an organization’s brand is a set of symbolic, functional and emotional benefits that are very difficult for competitors to replicate and that lead to organizational sustainability (King and Grace, 2010).

Throughout the past decades, there have been many efforts by professionals and academics to build strong brands that provide companies with a definitive competitive advantage (Kim *et al.*, 2003). Brand equity can be perceived as the measure of such efforts and has emerged as one of the most important marketing concepts for the first time in the 1980s (Bravo Gil *et al.*, 2007). Brand equity has been conceptualized as the intrinsic value that a brand adds to a tangible product or service (Fetscherin and Toncar, 2009).

Until very recently, brand equity was only observed from a financial or consumer perspective. Proponents of the financial perspective define brand equity as the total value of a brand when it is sold or included in a balance sheet (Atilgan *et al.*, 2009). On the other hand, customer-based brand equity (CBBE) represents the consumer perspective and can be analyzed as the differential effect that brand knowledge has on consumer response to brand marketing (Keller, 1998).

High levels of brand equity result in organizations having characteristics such as higher brand loyalty, brand awareness, positive customer perceptions and feelings, decreased price sensitivity, decreased financial and psychological risks, perceived quality, credibility and financial gains such as increased market share (de Chernatony and Cottam, 2006; DuBois Gelb and Rangarajan, 2014; Papasolomou and Vrontis, 2006). However, brands only become strong when the communicated brand promise is consistent with the delivered brand experience. And for this, there was a key stakeholder missing in the brand equity equation – the employee – as they play a central role in brand management. It is crucial that employees understand the organization’s brand, what it means to them, and how it correlates with their roles and responsibilities, to deliver the brand promise (de Chernatony and Cottam, 2006).

In addition to the undeniable importance of employees in building the brand, organizations are increasingly encouraging their employees to act as brand ambassadors (de Chernatony and Cottam, 2006), as differentiating brand elements, as loyal elements and with the role of brand endorsement (King *et al.*, 2012).

In this way, internal brand management (IBM) gains greater prominence (King and Grace, 2009, 2010). When we look at brand equity from the consumer’s point of view, the organization wants to promote long-term consumption behavior. In the case of an employee, the behavior is work-related, focused on fulfilling the brand promise.

EBBE can be seen as the differentiating effect that brand knowledge has on an employee's response to their work environment and requires translating the brand identity in a way that is meaningful to the employee in the context of their roles and responsibilities (King *et al.*, 2012; King and Grace, 2009, 2010). According to Ghose (2009), EBBE refers to the level of motivation of an employee to work for the brand's vision, along with the company's support to achieve the desired goals. EBBE can also be seen as the result of a scenario where employees have a high level of brand knowledge to stimulate positive behaviors aligned with the organization's brand identity (Brexendorf and Kernstock, 2007). Another view points out that EBBE captures the perceived added value that employees receive as a result of brand building efforts, resulting in an incremental effect of the brand on employee behavior (Baumgarth and Schmidt, 2010). For Tavassoli *et al.* (2014), EBBE can be seen as the value that a brand provides to a company through its effects on employees' attitudes and behaviors. There is also a perspective that refers to EBBE as the added meaning that employees receive from the brand beyond their work and the company's reputation, resulting in positive or negative behavior toward the company (Berger-Remy and Michel, 2015).

EBBE originates from the application of marketing principles to the field of human resource management, where employees are influenced by the company's image and have an impact on the company's identity. A measure of EBBE is considered a vital indicator of organizational efforts (King *et al.*, 2012). Academics and professionals should broaden their thinking and actions on how brands create value, how marketing returns are measured and how marketing should be involved in human resources and finance activities (Tavassoli *et al.*, 2014).

Given the necessary relationship between the marketing and human resources areas, it is important to clarify the difference with the term employer branding. EBBE and IBM aim to engage employees with the brand to deliver the brand promise (Burmahn and Zeplin, 2005). In contrast, employer branding focuses on promoting engagement among current and future employees to establish a perception that the organization is a great place to work (Lloyd, 2002).

The EBBE must be seen as a constant affective and cognitive route with employees (Boukis and Christodoulides, 2020), influenced by a set of factors, such as openness, knowledge dissemination, role clarity, commitment to the brand and information generation, that lead to various benefits such as brand citizenship behavior, employee satisfaction, intention to stay in the organization and positive word-of-mouth (King and Grace, 2009, 2010).

In their article, King *et al.* (2012) validated the EBBE scale across three core dimensions: brand loyalty, brand-consistent behavior and brand endorsement. This is the most commonly used scale in the articles analyzed in this systematic literature review. Brand loyalty refers to employees' future intention to stay with the organization. Brand-consistent behavior refers to employees' nonprescribed behaviors that are consistent with the brand and organizational values. Brand endorsement measures the extent to which employees are willing to share positive thoughts about the organization (brand) with others (King *et al.*, 2012; Poulis and Wisker, 2016).

Since its emergence in 2009, the concept of EBBE has evolved, with the academic world focusing on analyzing, understanding and measuring its model, causes and effects, leading to the growth of this topic and its more integrated and holistic interpretation. So far, no systematic literature review has been found on EBBE to determine what is known about this recent field of research.

When reading this study, it is possible to discover the following elements: a description of the methodology used in this systematic literature review, a bibliometric analysis of the considered articles, an analysis of the articles organized by thematic groups, the research agenda, the integrative framework and finally, the conclusion of the study. The conclusion

includes implications for the business and academic communities, as well as a discussion of the article's limitations.

2. Method

This article is based on a systematic literature review to identify, organize, synthesize and interpret the main findings of relevant studies on EBBE, as well as to present the evolution of this research field in recent years. Through this method, it is possible to identify the breadth of research that has been published, identify key themes and debates and highlight limitations and suggestions for future research. The focus of this work is the analysis of studies developed by the scientific community, allowing the identification of three thematic groups:

- (1) general model, causes and effects of EBBE;
- (2) the role of culture, leadership and context in EBBE; and
- (3) the role of brand management in EBBE.

This systematic literature review followed the structure of the five steps proposed by Khan *et al.* (2003): identification of the research question, identification of relevant studies, assessment of study quality, analysis/summary of evidence and interpretation/presentation of results.

Regarding the sample, two scientific databases were used: Web of Science and SCOPUS in April 2023 (See Figure 1). The search term “employee based brand equity” was first searched in the “topic” area to include studies that included the term in the title, abstract or keywords. Subsequently, the search was restricted to document type “article, review article, early access” published in English and in the categories “management, business, economics” in the case of WoS, and in the categories “Business, Management and Accounting; Social Sciences; Economics, Econometrics and Finance” in the case of SCOPUS. The same procedure was repeated with the term “employee brand equity.” Based on these criteria and steps, 30 articles were collected, with duplicates removed from both databases.

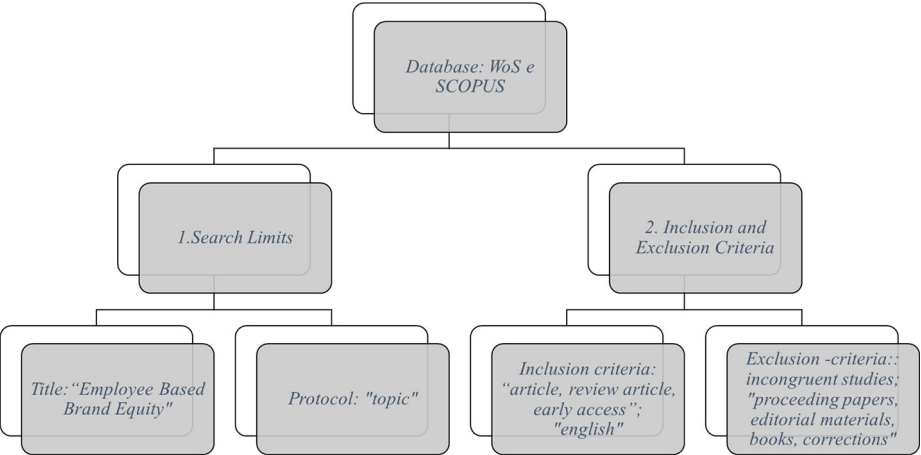


Figure 1.
Criteria of sample
selection

Source: Figure by authors

After collecting the articles, to find the clusters and proceed with the coding of the articles, it was used the approach proposed by Denyer and Tranfield (2009) and Sarka and Ipsen (2017). A summary of the information contained in each article was developed in terms of descriptive, methodological and thematic categories. For the thematic analysis, a more inductive approach was adopted, which analyzed and mapped the research discussion. Themes were extracted from the literature, grouped and eventually synthesized into analytical themes (Thomas and Harden, 2008). The aim was to identify the main predictors, mediators and strategies to adopt. Two authors independently coded the data to ensure reliability between coders (Cho, 2008). Where viewpoints differed, issues of disagreement were discussed between the authors until a resolution was reached (Cho, 2008).

The 30 articles in the sample were divided into three thematic groups according to the theme addressed and their contribution to understanding EBBE. The three thematic groups found were:

- (1) model, general causes and effects of EBBE;
- (2) the role of culture, leadership and context in EBBE; and
- (3) the role of brand management in EBBE (Table 1).

Thematic groups	No. articles	Authors of each thematic group
Model, general causes and effects of EBBE	15	King and Grace (2009) King and Grace (2010) Hanaysha and Al-Shaikh (2021) Boukis and Christodoulides (2020) Pitt <i>et al.</i> (2019) Tavassoli <i>et al.</i> (2014) Duh and Uford (2019) Mumtaz Awan and Wang (2018) Smith <i>et al.</i> (2021) Altaf <i>et al.</i> (2019) Altaf <i>et al.</i> (2017) Sanuri and Mokhtar (2018) Altaf and Shahzad (2018) Altaf <i>et al.</i> (2022) Hesse <i>et al.</i> (2022)
The role of culture, leadership and context in EBBE	7	Maleki Minbashrazgah <i>et al.</i> (2021) Mavuso <i>et al.</i> (2020) Lee <i>et al.</i> (2020) Nogueira <i>et al.</i> (2020) Wisker and Kwiatek (2019) Poulis and Wisker (2016) Wallace and de Chernatony (2011)
The role of brand management in EBBE	8	Liu <i>et al.</i> (2020) Deepa and Baral (2021) Kristanti (2017) Berger-Remy and Michel (2015) Xiong <i>et al.</i> (2013) Sarangal (2018) Huang and Lai (2021) Erkmen (2018)

Source: Table by authors

Table 1.
Thematic groups

It should be noted that the division of articles by content aimed to facilitate the understanding of each one's contribution to EBBE and not to restrict its analysis.

3. Sample description

From the extracted sample, it is possible to perceive that the EBBE theme is recent, having gained importance in recent years (Figure 2). Literature has already recognized that brands and human capital constitute the most important assets of companies and that the development of these assets is imperative in the current context for marketing and human resources professionals (Aaker, 1991; de Chernatony and Cottam, 2006; King and Grace, 2010; Poulis and Wisker, 2016). Thus, the relevance of the present theme is undeniable, and there has been a growing number of publications, especially in the past five years.

Through Figure 2, which reflects the 30 extracted articles, it is possible to determine that the first article dates back to 2009, demonstrating the recent interest in the topic. The year with the highest number of publications was 2018 and 2020, each with a total of six articles.

In addition to the recent interest in the topic, it is evident that there is a multidisciplinary interest. The 30 articles in the sample are published in 28 international journals. Most of the journals focus on the themes of marketing and management.

Regarding the methodologies used in the studied articles, it is noticeable that they are mostly quantitative, representing more than 80% of the sample (see Table 2).

4. Thematic groups

4.1 Theme Group 1: model, causes and general effects of employee-based brand equity

Fifteen articles were analyzed in this thematic group, of which thirteen are quantitative, one is qualitative and one is theoretical, which was the first article found on the subject under study. The main objectives of the first thematic group are to analyze the birth of the EBBE concept, its model, evolution as well as its main causes and effects.

The concept of EBBE emerged in 2009 in an article that introduced the term as a third perspective on brand equity. In this first article, the authors shared a framework with the dimensions of EBBE:

- IBM (generation of information; dissemination of knowledge; openness and human factor);

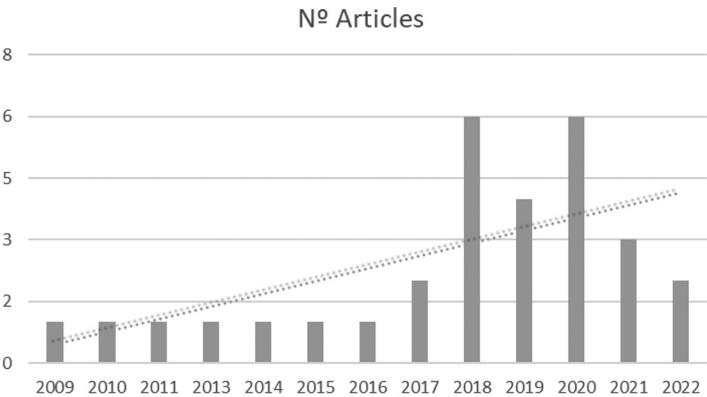


Figure 2.
Evolution of the
number of
publications

Source: Figure by authors

- effects of brand knowledge (clarity in function and commitment to the brand); and
- benefits (brand citizenship behavior, employee satisfaction, intention to stay in the organization, positive word-of-mouth).

For the authors, the desire to build EBBE is embedded in the vision that IBM's efforts bring benefits to the organization, which ultimately contributes to organizational effectiveness and success. Thus, the authors for the first time positioned EBBE as a predecessor to CBBE and financial brand equity (King and Grace, 2009). In the following year, the same authors empirically tested the EBBE model, and the results provided empirical validation for the model presented in 2009. The EBBE model reinforces the importance of IBM and the human factor and proposes that employees who understand how to fulfill the brand promise (clarity of function) and maintain a form of loyalty to the organization (commitment to the brand) will, through their attitudes and behaviors, contribute to a set of organizational benefits (EBBE benefits). Thus, the authors suggest that marketing professionals need to pay more attention to IBM (factors such as openness, the "H" factor and brand commitment) to facilitate cognitive reactions (e.g. information generation, knowledge dissemination and role clarity) that lead to shared organizational benefits (King and Grace, 2010).

In 2014, Tavassoli *et al.* (2014) complemented the EBBE view and empirically demonstrated its importance in executive compensation as an additional benefit. Executives value being associated with strong brands and therefore accept substantially lower salaries in companies that possess such brands. The research by these authors emphasizes that EBBE, in addition to supporting areas such as recruitment, can be a means for organizations to increase their profits through cost reductions, making it possible for companies to employ key people more affordably.

In 2018, it was time to test King and Grace's model in a culturally different environment. Based on data from China, the results show that openness, knowledge dissemination, role clarity and brand commitment have significant direct or indirect effects on EBBE, and information generation has a significant peripheral indirect effect on EBBE. It is once again proven that major brands need to manage EBBE to achieve better financial performance (Mumtaz Awan and Wang, 2018).

Research has been conducted that strongly links EBBE to brand engagement, even reflected in employee behavior on social networks such as Glassdoor and Instagram (Pitt *et al.*, 2019; Smith *et al.*, 2021). Recent research also demonstrates the importance of brand co-creation on social media by employees and its positive impact on EBBE (Hesse *et al.*, 2022). From a co-creative perspective, each social media activity undertaken by an employee has the potential to serve as a valuable contribution to a brand's equity (Hesse *et al.*, 2022). Concurrently, employees are gaining increasing empowerment to express their opinions on employer review sites and share work-related content on popular social media platforms such as Instagram or TikTok (Smith *et al.*, 2021).

Methodology	No. articles
Theoretical	1
Quantitative	25
Mixed	1
Qualitative	3

Source: Table by authors

Table 2.
Number of articles by
methodology

Some studies have also found that when employees understand their roles, have a solid understanding of their brand strength, and are committed to fulfilling the brand promise (i.e. positive EBBE), it leads to customers being willing to pay more for the services they receive (in this case associated with the banking sector), increasing brand preference. Therefore, CBBE needs to be supported by EBBE (Duh and Uford, 2019). In the context of the customer perspective, it has been proven that the dimensions of customer relationship management (CRM) have a positive impact on EBBE. Through CRM, employees can gain important insights into customers' needs and expectations and continue to serve them in the best way possible, especially when they have strong connections with the brand and receive positive feedback from management (Hanaysha and Al-Shaikh, 2021).

Several studies have been conducted in the Islamic banking sector. These studies show that employee brand commitment mediates the relationship between openness and EBBE, while brand role clarity does not have a mediating role (Altaf *et al.*, 2019). Furthermore, the cognitive and affective feelings of employees toward the brand are important in EBBE (Altaf *et al.*, 2017), and the understanding of the brand and the psychological ownership of the brand play a mediating role in the relationship between brand empowerment and EBBE (Sanuri and Mokhtar, 2018; Xiong *et al.*, 2013). Employee commitment to the brand strengthens the relationship between brand role clarity and EBBE (Altaf *et al.*, 2022).

In 2020, an integrated model of antecedents and consequences of EBBE was also tested. The model presented by Boukis and Christodoulides (2020) distinguishes a cognitive route and an affective route through two concepts: brand knowledge and brand identification. The study complements previous research by examining how employees' perceptions of their leadership roles impact EBBE. The evidence showed that leadership's role in the brand increases EBBE and that employees' cognitive and affective response to the brand is one of the main causes of EBBE. Brand knowledge is a strong predictor of EBBE, so promoting this knowledge should be one of the strategic priorities of organizations. However, it is also necessary to work on the affective route. In addition, the authors contribute to the fact that EBBE has a significant impact on the internal dissemination of the brand by colleagues, as well as being an important cause for customer orientation.

As visible through the articles in this thematic group, EBBE is a dynamic concept with much to explore. The main causes of EBBE are cognitive and affective, which lead to positive behaviors and attitudes of employees, contributing to CBBE and financial value creation for organizations.

4.2 Theme Group 2: the role of culture, leadership and context in employee-based brand equity

Seven articles were analyzed within this thematic group, consisting of one mixed methods study, one qualitative study and five quantitative studies. These studies collectively demonstrate the significant influence of culture, context and leadership on EBBE.

Culture encompasses the values, beliefs and behaviors of employees and explains the organizational functioning (Deshpande and Webster, 1989 as cited in Mavuso *et al.*, 2020). Mavuso *et al.* (2020) conducted a study in which they found that the four dimensions of organizational culture, namely, involvement, consistency, adaptability and mission, were positively and significantly related to EBBE. The study results offer evidence-based recommendations to prioritize EBBE and leverage organizational culture to achieve brand equity. From a business standpoint, this study indicates that for organizations to achieve competitiveness through brand equity, it is important to focus on dimensions of organizational culture. Wallace and de Chernatony (2011) also conducted a qualitative study that allowed them to examine the influence of service company culture on the interpretation of brand role

and the development and implementation of brand values. They quickly realized that culture is closely linked with these factors and suggested a model presented as a “hierarchy of change.” The model identifies that in all cultural contexts, brand values must be created from the bottom up, based on consultation among all, regardless of seniority. To incorporate an appropriate set of values, senior managers should consider the brand as an “experience” rather than a “product plus” and ensure that brand champions are consistent in their interpretation of the brand. In their model, the authors recommend that frontline employees be directly involved in the continuous development and dissemination of brand values.

The role of leadership in branding is a crucial target for analysis in EBBE. It all starts with the specific brand leadership theory, developed by [Morhart *et al.* \(2009\)](#) through a combination of self-determination theory, social identity theory and brand construction theory, which emphasizes that brand values and identity should be internalized in employees by leaders of a company (as cited in [Lee *et al.*, \(2020\)](#)). Leadership can occur in two forms: transactional leadership (TRL) and transformational leadership (TFL). TFL refers to the leadership style that motivates followers to act as ambassadors for the corporate brand, appealing to their personal values and beliefs. TRL refers to the leadership style that motivates followers to act as ambassadors for the corporate brand, using a logic of contingency and basic needs of employees as an appeal ([Morhart *et al.*, 2009](#) as cited in [Lee *et al.*, \(2020\)](#)). In the study conducted by [Lee *et al.* \(2020\)](#), the results imply that both TFL and TRL require the mediation of person-job fit and person-group fit to influence EBBE, which, in turn, influences brand equity. On the other hand, the study by [Maleki Minbashrazgah *et al.* \(2021\)](#) examines the role of TRL in implementing the new approach to brand building behaviors (BBBs) and EBBE. This study revealed that TRL is important for employees to exhibit BBBs. The results show that TRL affects participation and retention positively and significantly. In addition, the variables of participation, in-role brand building behavior (IRBBB), and retention have a positive and significant effect on EBBE. However, no significant relationship was found between TRL and IRBBB. By implementing TRL, leaders can see more employee participation in brand experiences, loyalty and retention in the company. However, alongside TRL, the transformational dimension in brand behavior is increasingly relevant, so further studies on TFL may be welcome.

[Poulis and Wisker \(2016\)](#) explored how EBBE and perceived environmental uncertainty (PEU) affect company performance. Of the six PEU hypotheses related to EBBE, four hypotheses received strong statistical support: the effect of perceived macroeconomic uncertainties, the effect of perceived resources and service uncertainties, the effect of perceived product market and demand uncertainties and the effect of perceived competition uncertainties. Thus, EBBE cannot be analyzed without taking the existing context into account. In the case of [Wisker and Kwiatek \(2019\)](#), the results of their study showed that EBBE partially mediates the relationship between environmental orientation and organizational performance. The study observed a positive effect of environmental orientation on EBBE. Therefore, the study suggests that hoteliers need to be environmentally sensitive to attract, recruit and retain worthy employees to achieve better business results. Finally, we present the study by [Nogueira *et al.* \(2020\)](#), which explores EBBE in a different context, the context of volunteering. The findings of this study reinforced the primary role played by job clarity and commitment to the brand in engaging volunteers with their brand, which affects their overall satisfaction and motivation to remain in the organization.

Through this thematic group, it is possible to observe that culture, the role of leadership in the brand, environmental orientation and organizational contexts must be taken into account in the analysis of EBBE.

4.3 Theme Group 3: the role of brand management in employee-based brand equity

Eight articles were analyzed within this thematic group, seven of which are quantitative and one is qualitative. This thematic group aims to delve deeper into the brand management efforts that companies have to make and which aspects of the brand they should be aware of to achieve EBBE and, consequently, CBBE and financial performance.

A study by [Xiong et al. \(2013\)](#) shows that employees' brand attitude and behavior are influenced by different brand understanding factors. Relational factors (perceived brand importance to the employee and relevance of the brand role) are the main antecedents of employee brand commitment. The results suggest that while perceived brand knowledge can contribute to EBBE, employees must see the brand as significant and relevant to embrace their role as brand ambassadors. [Berger-Remy and Michel \(2015\)](#) also suggest that brands, through the meaning they convey or the identity they embody, can trigger employee attitudes and behaviors – whether positive (pride, work motivation, positive word-of-mouth) or negative (criticism, disengagement from the company). To increase EBBE, it is important to encourage employees to embrace the brand, even those who are not naturally in contact with the brand in their profession. The authors suggest that the brand identity be formalized among employees to give them the means to experience the brand from a moral, psychological and physical perspective. It is necessary to identify, develop and sustain aspects of the brand that mean something to employees, providing direction, content and sensations – more than simply transposing the relationship of customers with the brand. EBBE thus highlights the importance of brand management in building meaning in a social context ([Berger-Remy and Michel, 2015](#)). Effective integrated communication is crucial in achieving an employee value proposition (EVP) that aligns with the organization's brand promise, and can, therefore, benefit EBBE. When employees experience coordination and consistency in brand communication, they perceive that the psychological contract (in terms of EVP attributes) is being fulfilled, resulting in positive behaviors and attitudes toward the brand, leading to EBBE benefits ([Deepa and Baral, 2021](#)).

[Liu et al. \(2020\)](#) also emphasize the importance of working on the brand identity (set of associations the brand wants to create and maintain), as it positively affects the internalization of the brand by employees, leading to a positive EBBE. Internalizing the brand refers to effectively communicating the brand to employees, conveying its relevance and value. [Sarangal \(2018\)](#) reflects on the importance of internal marketing practices for EBBE. From the perspective of internal marketing, employees should be seen as customers and trained, motivated and satisfied to build a positive internal customer. Thus, focusing on internal marketing activities will lead to higher EBBE and, consequently, support the achievement of organizational strategic objectives.

[Kristanti \(2017\)](#) reinforces the strategic role of branding in the corporate competitive advantage of organizations and studies the relationship between corporate brand personality and sustainable brand value, finding that corporate brand personality provides a good explanation of the influence of sustainable brand value. Corporate brand personality is defined as a first-order latent construct, where employees are required to express a high degree of identification to score high on sustainable brand value and emerge as brand champions.

[Huang and Lai \(2021\)](#) highlight that the establishment of EBBE can be achieved through internal branding management in medical service environments and has positive effects on employees' organizational citizenship behavior and job performance. In [Erkmen \(2018\)](#) research, it is demonstrated that internal communication increases brand knowledge and role clarity, while external communication and employees' brand experience positively affect employees' brand commitment. The construction of EBBE is an internal process that involves various mechanisms, each with a distinct role in building the brand.

Through this thematic group, the importance of companies investing in IBM activities, brand identity and internal marketing is made clear to achieve all the benefits of EBBE.

5. Research agenda and framework

After a deep examination of the contributions of the studies analyzed in this systematic literature review, the main suggestions for future research will be summarized by thematic group.

Through an analysis of the research suggestions present in the articles of the first thematic group – general model, causes and effects of EBBE – it is possible to verify that this is still a new field of research with much to explore.

The authors recommend testing the EBBE model in more countries, regions and industry sectors, as research has mainly focused on service companies. Several authors suggest research in industrial and business-to-business environments. Testing EBBE in business to business (B2B) and industrial businesses is of significant importance for several reasons. First, B2B companies operate within unique market dynamics, where these organizations often engage in long-term relationships and partnerships with other businesses, relying heavily on trust, credibility and reputation. Second, in B2B environments employees, as representatives of their organizations, play a crucial role in establishing and maintaining relationships with clients, influencing their perceptions of the brand and fostering long-term loyalty. Additionally, B2B businesses often operate in niche markets with specialized products or services. In these industries, brand differentiation and value proposition are key factors in achieving a competitive advantage. Overall, testing EBBE in B2B and industrial businesses allows for a more comprehensive understanding of how employee perceptions, attitudes and behaviors shape brand equity in these unique contexts. The findings can inform strategic decision-making, marketing efforts and employee engagement initiatives, ultimately leading to enhanced brand performance and competitive advantage in B2B and industrial markets (Altaf *et al.*, 2022; King and Grace, 2009; Uford and Duh, 2021).

It is also noticeable that there is a suggestion for the use of different methodologies. More than 80% of the articles in this sample are quantitative, which indicates the need for more qualitative research, more case studies and more longitudinal research for a deeper understanding of the topic.

The recommendations for future research also include multigroup analysis across different sectors and types of companies, investigating antecedents and behavioral outcomes in different contexts, conducting comparative studies across different countries and replicating the study in other industries.

This thematic group also reveals the need to investigate in more detail the relationship between EBBE and CBBE and Financial based brand equity (FBBE). Investigating the relationship between them is crucial for gaining a comprehensive understanding of brand performance and making informed strategic decisions. It helps organizations ensure brand consistency, foster customer loyalty and advocacy, improve financial performance and gain a competitive advantage. The relationship between these variables highlights the importance of aligning employees with the brand, creating positive customer experiences and measuring the impact of employee branding initiatives on financial outcomes (Boukis and Christodoulides, 2020; Tavassoli *et al.*, 2014).

In the articles of the second thematic group – the Role of Culture, Leadership and Context in EBBE – there are still suggestions for more qualitative and longitudinal research to advance this field. These articles also reinforce the importance of analyzing the impact of EBBE on the company's financial performance. By conducting longitudinal research, scholars can gain a deeper understanding of the temporal dynamics and causal relationships between EBBE, cultural factors, leadership practices and organizational context. These studies can help identify the long-term effects of specific interventions, initiatives or changes in these factors on the development and sustainability of EBBE (Lee *et al.*, 2020; Maleki Minbashrazgah *et al.*, 2021).

One of the prominent themes within the research on EBBE is the role of brand leadership, particularly TRL or TFL, and its impact on EBBE. To further advance this field, future research could adopt a more diversified approach to studying leadership styles, such as using comprehensive 360-degree self-assessment methods. Moreover, researchers can consider incorporating additional leadership variables to explore the relationships and mediating effects between employees and brand equity, providing a more comprehensive contribution to the existing body of research. By exploring these aspects, we can enhance our understanding of how different leadership styles and variables impact EBBE and contribute to the overall brand management efforts within organizations (Lee *et al.*, 2020; Maleki Minbashrazgah *et al.*, 2021).

Further analysis of EBBE in diverse social contexts and exploration of volunteer-based brand equity (VBBE) are essential for a comprehensive understanding of the topic. Research should investigate differences among volunteers from various social backgrounds, using a broader and more comprehensive panel of experts. The use of the Delphi method on a larger scale can provide valuable insights into the dimensions of EBBE in the context of formal volunteering. Additionally, it is advised to examine variables such as coordination/management roles, volunteer tenure and hours dedicated to volunteer activities to assess their impact on VBBE (Nogueira *et al.*, 2020).

The connection between organizational culture and brand values to EBBE can also be a theme that is more explored in future research. Investigating the connection between organizational culture and brand values to EBBE is crucial for understanding how internal culture influences employee perceptions and behaviors toward the brand. This research can provide insights into developing strategies to align the organizational culture with brand values, strengthen employee engagement and deliver a consistent brand experience. It can also shed light on the mechanisms through which culture impacts EBBE, such as leadership styles and communication channels. By fostering a positive culture that supports brand values, organizations can build customer trust, loyalty and long-term brand equity (Mavuso *et al.*, 2020; Wallace and de Chernatony, 2011).

Moving on to the suggestions given in the third thematic group – the role of brand management in EBBE – we find again the suggestion of qualitative and longitudinal research exploring different countries and areas of activity. A multi-level research that encompasses companies, employees and customers for a deeper understanding of EBBE and the effects of brand management is also suggested.

For the authors, it is relevant to understand how different employees react to brand stimuli and, for example, the impact of employee seniority. They also suggest analyzing the impact of internal marketing actions (formal and informal). These suggestions can be considered due to several reasons. First, employees at different levels of seniority may have varying levels of familiarity and alignment with the brand, which can influence their perceptions and behaviors. Second, seniority can also affect the extent to which employees have been exposed to internal marketing actions and initiatives, potentially influencing their engagement and understanding of the brand. Additionally, analyzing the impact of both formal and informal internal marketing actions provides insights into the effectiveness of different strategies in shaping employee perceptions and fostering brand alignment. By exploring these factors, organizations can develop targeted and tailored approaches to enhance EBBE and overall brand performance (Liu *et al.*, 2020; Xiong *et al.*, 2013).

Through a critical analysis of the research profile and the themes extracted from this systematic literature review, it was possible to identify and summarize a set of future research opportunities. Table 3 highlights the main themes and research questions.

The analysis of the limitations found thus gives rise to a framework that can serve as a basis for a research agenda.

Themes	Sub-themes	Research questions for future investigation
Causes and effects of EBBE	Relationship with CBBE	What are the sources of CBBE and EBBE? What is the impact of EBBE on factors such as resistance to persuasive advertising from competitors and willingness of customers and employees to engage in positive word-of-mouth? How do fluctuations in EBBE impact CBBE? Which EBBE factors have the greatest influence on CBBE?
	EBBE in B2B companies Relationship with FBBE	How does the EBBE model behave in B2B companies and with B2B employees? What is the impact of EBBE on FBBE? What is the effect of EBBE on organizational performance metrics, such as sales and customer satisfaction?
Culture, leadership and context in EBBE	Role of leadership	How does TFL affect EBBE and CBBE? What type of leadership has a greater impact on EBBE – TFL or TRL? How does leadership mediate the relationship of employees with the brand? How does TFL impact employees' adoption of brand values?
	Role of culture	Does the adoption of values by employees directly influence EBBE?
	Role of context	How do contextual factors such as trust and organizational prestige affect EBBE? How do employee characteristics affect EBBE? What is the impact of different social contexts on VBBE?
Role of brand management in EBBE	IBM and IM Employer branding	What is the impact of IBM or IM initiatives on EBBE? What is the impact of employer branding on EBBE?

Note: IM = Internal marketing

Source: Table by authors

Table 3.
Research questions
based on themes and
gaps

This structure emphasizes the various aspects of the theme that are worth exploring, based on the content analysis of the selected studies (Figure 3).

Through Figure 3, we can understand that the entire system of EBBE is a process that delivers value to the employee, the customer and the company/business. As antecedents, it is possible to identify those related to leadership, culture, context, as well as those related to brand management itself. These antecedents will cause employees to have a set of positive behaviors and attitudes that make the brand promise delivered. Through EBBE, it is possible to achieve results such as CBBE and FBBE, among others.

This integrative structure of EBBE reveals the relevance of continuing research in this field to better understand the sources and consequences of EBBE, as well as how value is delivered to employees, customers and the company throughout the process.

6. Conclusion, implications and limitations

The present systematic literature review on EBBE contributes to the literature through a comprehensive review of the state-of-the-art, an understanding of the evolution of the concept and a deep exploration of its main areas, causes and effects.

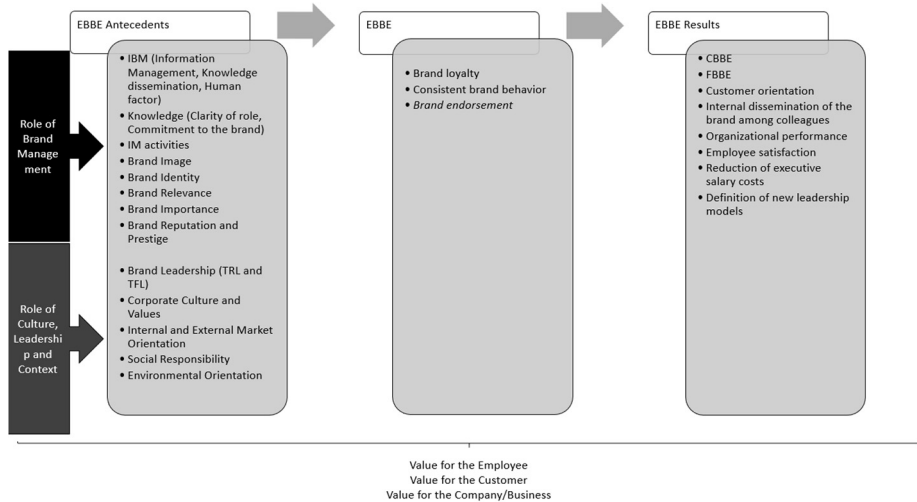


Figure 3.
EBBE framework

Source: Figure by authors

To investigate these main areas, a content analysis was conducted by thematic groups. The analysis of 30 articles resulted in three main thematic groups: general model, causes and effects of EBBE; the role of culture, leadership and context in EBBE; the role of brand management in EBBE. In addition to the analysis of each of these thematic groups, this article contributes to the literature through its synthesis, creating an integrative structure of EBBE that lists its antecedents (whether in the order of brand management, culture, context or leadership) as well as its results, where value is delivered to the employee, customer and the company throughout the process (Figure 3). This structure also summarizes the evolution of this concept, considering the contribution of the articles found.

This study also demonstrates the increasing importance of EBBE for the academic and business world since 2009. In fact, EBBE and brand equity are topics of real interest because building, maintaining and using brands to achieve a sustainable strategic advantage is a reality (Erdem *et al.*, 1999). Therefore, marketing literature promotes a greater understanding of the impact of brand-building efforts to enrich future brand management practices (King *et al.*, 2012). And to understand the impact of these efforts, it would be a mistake not to investigate the role of employees (King and Grace, 2009). Organizations are increasingly encouraging their employees to be their main ambassadors, so a measure of EBBE should be considered a vital indicator of organizational efforts (de Chernatony and Cottam, 2006; King *et al.*, 2012a).

This article brings important implications for management and business practice, supporting companies in exploring the definitive and sustainable competitive advantage that characterizes brand equity. The focus on internal brand communication is clear. But how to communicate and demonstrate the brand? In this article, it is noticeable that it is not enough to copy what is done for customers. It is necessary to understand who the employees are and communicate the brand in a way that is meaningful and relevant to them (Berger-Remy and Michel, 2015). But in addition to the focus on the brand management area, as evidenced from the outset in the EBBE model (King and Grace, 2009), professionals should pay attention to their leaders and their role in transmitting brand values, as well as

considering the organizational culture and context in which they operate. Only through the analysis and optimization of all these variables is it possible to achieve EBBE and consequently, CBBE and financial performance.

In addition to the contributions to the business world, this article also provides guidance for the academic world. The main research gaps in this area were identified, and research questions were formulated to guide future studies. In addition to the need for more qualitative, multilevel and longitudinal research, it is necessary to test the EBBE model in more countries, regions and sectors, such as industry. Furthermore, it is important to investigate more deeply the connection between EBBE and CBBE, the connection between EBBE and FBBE, culture as a precursor to EBBE, the role of leadership in EBBE, the role of context in EBBE, the influence of employee personal characteristics on EBBE, as well as the best practices of IBM and IM that influence EBBE.

Despite the contributions of this study, it is important to acknowledge its limitations. The main limitation is related to the sample used. Only articles from two scientific databases (SCOPUS and WoS) were considered, so it is recommended to broaden the databases in future reviews to analyze more articles on the subject.

Finally, it is worth noting that EBBE is a strategic factor for organizations, and marketers, managers and human resources professionals should work together in a multidisciplinary and integrated way to achieve the long-awaited competitive advantage for organizations. Strong brands cannot exist if the brand promise is not fulfilled, and this can only be achieved through employee engagement, commitment and satisfaction. Brand equity has only one way to start – internally. Therefore, it is necessary to develop and pay attention to areas such as brand management, leadership, culture and context to achieve EBBE and, consequently, CBBE and financial performance.

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